

Figure 6. Nishadraj Temple on Nishadraj Ghat

Scenes from this mythic story appear on walls at a few ghats, and it's clear that the Mallahs derive some dignity, pride and power from this association (another famous Nishad is Eklavya in the Mahabharata). Nandini Majumdar, author of *Banaras: Walks through India's Sacred City*, writes that as part of the colonial era 'reforms' and Sanskritization (a process by which an entire caste tries to attain upward caste mobility), 'the Nishads of Banaras deified an ancestor, Nishadraj' and built an airy temple to him on a ghat named after him. The small temple has a splendid view of the river and seems to attract mid-day slumberers on its shady mosaic floor.

The Mallahs also call themselves Ganga-*putra*s, or sons of the river goddess Ganga. In this capacity, they often perform certain lifecycle rituals for the pilgrims, especially the ones that involve offerings to Ganga Ma for childbirth, marriage or vows of propitiation. Such rituals as the Mallahs perform often resemble Brahminical ones and even include the chanting of mantras, prohibited for lower Shudra castes like the Mallahs. On the river, it seems, many rules of caste and religion exhibit a measure of fluidity.

A local contact leads me to Santosh, a leader of the Mallah community. We meet near Assi Ghat and he takes me to his tiny home in a tangled gully